Then the USSR intervened. The Soviet government regarded Syria as a key ally in the Middle East. On 13 May the Soviets warned the Egyptian government that Israel was moving its armed forces to the border with Syria, Egypt's ally, and was planning to attack. This was not true. Moreover, Nasser knew the Soviet report was untrue. The Soviets were either mistaken or were lying. Perhaps they saw an opportunity to expand their influence in the region at a time when the USA was bogged down in **Vietnam**.

Nevertheless, the story spread rapidly. Arab eyes were on Nasser. What would he do? He did not want war as he knew that Israeli forces were far superior to those of the Arab states yet he had to respond because his leadership of the Arab world was being challenged. Since the attack on Samu, the Jordanians had been accusing Nasser of cowardice and of hiding behind the protection of the UN troops. Besides, he had a defence agreement with Syria compelling Egypt to go to Syria's aid if Syria was attacked by Israel. As the historian Avi Shlaim put it: 'What he did was to embark on an exercise in **brinkmanship** that was to carry him over the brink.'

Key terms

Vietnam
The USA had a large military force fighting against communist North Vietnam and its communist allies in South Vietnam.

Brinkmanship
Pursuing a dangerous policy to the limits of safety.

Nasser's next moves

Nasser took three steps, both to deter Israel and to impress Arab public opinion:

- First, on 15 May he moved 100,000 Egyptian troops into Sinai (see the map on page 52). This was Egyptian territory but it alarmed the Israelis because it brought Egyptian troops nearer to Israel.
- Secondly, he asked the UN commander to remove his troops from Egyptian soil. He wanted to prove that Egypt was completely independent. The UN forces could stay on Egyptian territory only as long as Egypt allowed them. The UN Secretary-General proposed that the UN troops be placed on

Key date

Nasser moved Egyptian troops into Sinai: 15 May 1967

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A cartoon published in a Lebanese Arab newspaper in May 1967. Each cannon has the name of a different Arab state on it, but Egypt is not one of them. What is the message of the cartoon? Why do you think the name of Egypt is omitted?